

Ubuntu hasn't let go of the old GNOME that paints the whole town yellow (Figure 1). Brown and yellow have now been used for too long, and that bright yellow wallpaper gets on your nerves. However, I've got to admit, they have the best GNOME implementation around. That sounds contradictory? Well, looks are not everything; what counts is how integrated the DE is with the rest of the system and vice versa. If you want GNOME, nothing else will do. Kubuntu is a refreshing surprise though, and it's not just KDE4 that looks good (Figure 2); Kubuntu has perfected the desktop layout, text and panel sizes and text anti-aliasing—the results are awesome.

Mandriva makes me angry. And I'm sure many Mandriva users will be, after checking out its hideous looks. I'll forgive you if you spread the news that Mandriva uses KDE1 as its default UI (Figure 6). I'll forgive you if you think this release was made in 1989. On the upside, the Mandriva developers have worked on KDE's Semantic Desktop (the Nepomuk-Strigi combo) feature and, unlike the other two, it's enabled and integrated out-of-the-box. Although I'm still not used to the idea, you can have a better understanding of its capabilities at <http://doc4.mandriva.org/bin/view/labs/Nepomuk-mdv2010-RC>.

The Good	openSUSE 11.2
The Bad	(K)Ubuntu
The Ugly	Mandriva 2010

Criteria 5: Multimedia support and other proprietary stuff

Let's start with Ubuntu 9.10. The only codecs that it comes with are Ogg Vorbis and Theora. However, installing additional ones is a breeze. Once you play any

unsupported file (such as MP3) in Totem or Rhythmbox, a dialogue box pops up and installs all the GStreamer codecs. Flash, however, needs to be installed manually. Over at Kubuntu's stable, it's much better, as Kubuntu automatically installs all the codecs, including Flash, the moment it detects a working Internet connection. So one doesn't really feel that any codecs are missing! Way to go!

Coming to openSUSE 11.2, even this guy comes with only the Ogg codecs. However, no automated installation procedures exist. What you need to do is get into YaST!, open the Software Repositories module and hit Add. In the next screen, select Community Repositories and enable VideoLan and Packman repos. Finish up the wizard and the Software Repositories module, and close YaST!. Open a terminal, and run: `sudo zypper dup`. You are good to go.

And at Mandriva's stable, everything is included, except very exotic stuff like Dirac and AAC. You can just head to Mandriva's Control Centre and then to the Package Manager; then search for gst, and enable everything. You are covered—mostly! Add the PLF repos (from easyurpmi.zarb.org), open a terminal and execute `urpmi --auto-select`. This will replace the somewhat restricted codecs with the fully-liberated ones—thanks to the Penguin Liberation Front :-)

Coming to proprietary graphics drivers, over at Mandriva, this is one no-brainer to install. Head to MCC, and then to X configuration. Don't change anything; just keep hitting 'Next'. Just before the summary screen, MCC will inform you that proprietary drivers that perform better are available, and if you would like to use them, hit 'Yes', and they are installed. Log out and back in, and it's done.

In (K)Ubuntu, the Jockey applet starts up on the first boot, showing a list of hardware that need proprietary drivers (it included only Nvidia G96 (9400GT) in my case)—refer to Figure 13. Select a driver version, hit 'Activate', and reboot. (You don't really need to reboot;



Figure 13: Ubuntu suggests I should be better off with NVIDIA's non-free drivers



Figure 14: The Mandriva control centre continues to make life easier